

SELFIE SADHUS
Naga sadhus during the Mahakumbh at Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, Jan. 6

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



favourite movies and cricket matches. "The monthly recharge costs me Rs 349. I can seamlessly watch all matches and movies," he says. A big fan of stars like Shah Rukh Khan and Shraddha Kapoor, he sometimes follows them and posts videos he shoots of them on his YouTube channel. ■

THE EASE OF LIVING

That communication landscape stands vastly changed today, with a mobile phone in almost every hand in India. As of October 2024, there were 1.15 billion mobile subscribers, of which around 1.06 billion were active; and 928 million wireless internet subscribers as of June 2024. The cost of calls has come down to just 3 paisa per minute, and that of mobile data Rs 9.08 per GB, among the lowest in the world. India leads globally in monthly average data consumption per smartphone, consuming 32 GB of data on average compared to 19 GB globally.

And things are slated to get only better. 5G services, launched in late 2022 in India, promise to change the world as we know it. Expect faster speeds at a quicker response time, the era of 4K and 8K televisions, and virtual reality (VR) applications. It will also spell transformational change for the common man, as Amitabh Kant, former CEO of NITI Aayog, points out—a fillip to digital education, point-of-care diagnostics and connected ambulance services in healthcare; the next level of simple, seamless and secure payments; improve charging infrastructure for electric vehicles; integrate initiatives across transit systems like FASTag for toll and entry tax; help monitor farms for the health of crops, or impart virtual training in irrigation; and boost the efficiency on the shop floor. The future, clearly, is here. ■